

CPC Adult Sunday Studies

Fall 2026 |

The Wonders of Communal Worship #4

The Structure of Communal Worship

Last Week: God commands us to worship him on the Lord's Day, and we are to regulate (Word) and direct (forms) our worship according to his Word. God graciously invites us into communion with himself in Christ through the Spirit. Today, we're beginning to look into the specifics of what we're actually supposed to do in worship.

1 | WHAT HAPPENS WHEN PEOPLE ENTER GOD'S PRESENCE?

Biblical Patterns - we're given elements and patterns, but not detailed directives. "The lack of explicit detail must reflect an intention to guide us by transcendent principles rather than by specific worship forms that could become culture-bound, time-locked, and superstition-invoking." (Chappell, *Christ-Centered Worship*, 108) There are many psalms that don't reflect an exact structure that must be adhered to, though they always reflect an awareness of being in God's presence. We want to avoid both extremes of doing whatever we want in worship and insisting on only ever doing the exact same thing.

Read Isaiah 6:1-8

Notice the structure:

1. Overwhelmed by God's presence and holiness (vv. 1-4)
2. Confession of Sin (v. 5)
3. Forgiveness (v. 6-7)
4. God speaks (v. 8ff.)

1Kings 8 (cf. *2Chron. 5-7*) — Solomon's prayer at the building of the Temple. Similar themes, though it's not a typical worship service, of God's holiness; pleas for forgiveness, presence, and help; sacrifice and forgiveness; God speaking (ch. 9).

Nehemiah 8-11 — Nehemiah leading the people of Israel in worship, confession of sin, hearing the Law, and saying of vows.

Psalms 9, 11, 15, 24, 29, 33, 34, 46, 48, 57, 65-68, 78, 81, 84-87, 90-108, 110-115, 118, 120-134 (Song of Ascents, sung upon walking up to the Temple in worship), *135-138, 145-150*— Examples of different forms of communal worship, and there's probably more!

1Cor. 11-14—on regulating worship for the purpose of participating in the Lord's Supper faithfully, the edification of the church and reaching nonbelievers in worship

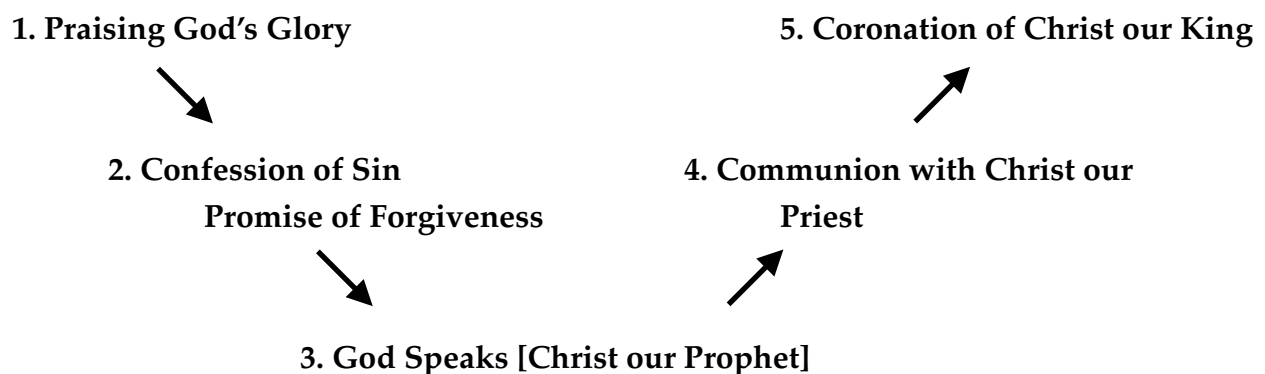
Read Revelation 4-5:

1. Praise & Adoration: 4:1-2, 6-8
2. Confession of Sin and Forgiveness: 5:1-5
3. God Speaks, People Respond: 5:6-9 - the scroll is the words to be revealed in the rest of Revelation
4. People Commune: 5:9 - Note, there wouldn't be an actual Lord's Supper in the presence of Jesus himself
5. Christ is Crowned: 5:10-13

2 | THE LOGIC OF THE GOSPEL

Long before Marshall McLuhan coined the phrase "the medium is the message," God's people were worshipping according to the logic and structure of the gospel! Everyone has a liturgy and our worship patterns always communicate something, it's unavoidable.

Gospel Arc - our worship service has a general macro arc to it, starting from God, down to humanity, and ending back "up" with God. There are also micro arcs within each movement that reflect the same pattern.



What is the story that this structure tells? What is the message that this medium displays? We start with God and his glory, who is worthy of worship; that naturally leads us to feel unworthy in his presence, so we confess our sin, but because of who God is in Christ, he forgives us. Having welcomed us into his presence and cleansed us, he now speaks to us by his Word—which itself is confirmed at the Lord's table, the

visible Word; and we naturally want to crown him as our King again, having fed us by his Word and Sacrament, as he leaves us with a blessing.

The first two movements welcome us into the Holy of Holies, and now that we've been welcomed, we can commune with Christ who is our prophet, priest and King.

Variations within the structure

There are small variations that the church over the centuries have dealt with, since we're not commanded to always follow this order. At CPC, we've also varied over the years. For instance, fronting the confession of sin even further could highlight more the fact that we are sinners in desperate need of God's grace, even before saying a word. Or, we move from Praising immediately to the sermon, and place the confession of sin and forgiveness sequence within the Lord's table movement of communion. There are pros and cons to each, and sometimes depend upon the culture of the church, needs of the community, styles, etc.

What does it say about the gospel if we exclude one of these movements:

- Praise and Adoration?
- Confession of Sin? - "it is reasonable to question whether worship is Christian worship at all if there is no opportunity for confession. Human confession is the reflex response of divine encounter." (88)
- Sermon?
- Lord's Supper?

Not only would excluding any of these diminish the gospel, it would also diminish the **emotional depth of the worship service**, implying that only certain emotions are fit to bring to God. The Psalms and the gospel itself, however, make very clear that every human emotion is fitting for an encounter with the living God (yearning, wonder, joyfulness, sadness, resoluteness, humbleness, etc); Jesus was fully human, yet without sin. We don't just bring our happy-go-lucky emotions!

Note also how this structure should inform our **individual prayer life**—think of A.C.T.S. (adoration, confession, thanksgiving, supplication)—not as an unbending rule, but as the general flow of what it means to come into God's presence. If we jump to "S" God becomes merely the servant of our needs. If we stay in "A" we forget God wants our flourishing and sanctification in Christ.

3 | SPECIFICS WITHIN MOVEMENTS 1 AND 2

Praising God's Glory: Reverence and Rejoicing

- Starts with God: God calls us to worship because worship is not our idea or primarily our work, but God's. He commands us to worship and he starts it.
 - We respond: in song and prayer, we *"ascribe to the LORD the glory due his name; worship the LORD in the splendor of holiness"* (Psalm. 29.1-2)
- This section should include songs focused on God, without necessarily first considering how God has forgiven us (though often they're mixed together). These songs should be "You, God, are...." whereas thanksgiving songs are "I thank you for..."
- Through worship, we rediscover the holy otherness of God revealed through creation and salvation. Praise songs serve as prayers that give voice to the worship God is due.

Receiving God's Grace: Repentance and Reconciliation

- Note what this implies about the Christian life: we will never outgrow our need to confess our sins; instead, repentance and faith are the cycles of growth itself, as we grow in our hatred of sin and appreciation of God's mercy.
- **Praying prayers of confession:** sometimes we pray prayers of confession for things we may not feel in the moment. In a culture obsessed with authenticity, this may feel disingenuous. **The goal of a liturgy**, however, is not simply to give voice to what we already feel (which assumes we've got it figured out, know how to pray, and the outward is merely tangential), but also to train us in how to think and feel in ways we don't yet. We're not just putting our mouths where our heart already is, but putting our hearts where our mouth is. For instance, if I pray "forgive me for my covetousness," though I'm not aware of having coveted all week, it should draw me to consider my blindspots. In addition, **the importance of confessing communally** is that we are sharing the burdens of one another since, as the body of Christ, we belong to one another (note Isa. 6:5, *"people"*); so, we confess that we live in a world of covetousness even if I don't struggle with it particularly. In the same way, we sing songs of thanksgiving often in two minds: "thank you God" and "oh, how I need to grow in thankfulness to you, so may this song work that in me!" Obviously, this also needs to be balanced with simple deceit, if we don't mean the words at all.
- As our worship guide explains, "entering God's presence naturally leads us to face our sin, yet in Christ we do so both mournfully and courageously, with the knowledge that his abundant mercy awaits. God makes it safe to be honest, real, and transparent about our moral failures and brokenness because we have nothing to prove or hide in Christ."